



Grade 5
General
English Language Arts

Directions:

On the following pages of your practice test booklet are questions for the Grade 5 *Nebraska Student-Centered Assessment System (NSCAS) General English Language Arts* practice test.

Read these directions carefully before beginning the test.

This practice test will include several different types of questions. Some questions are based on a passage. Multiple choice questions will ask you to select an answer from among four choices. Multiple select questions will ask you to select multiple correct answers from among five or more answer choices. For some questions, there may be two parts, Part A and Part B, where each part has a multiple choice or multiple select question. Some questions will ask you to construct an answer by following the directions given.

For all questions:

- Read each question carefully and choose the best answer.
- You may use scratch paper to make notes.
- Be sure to answer ALL the questions.

Read the passage.

A Traveling Experience

- 1 Ms. Collins raised her arm in the air. Like everyone else in the classroom, Jordan knew that the gesture meant it was time to be quiet and listen. The students watched as their teacher pulled down a large map of the United States.
- 2 “What are some ways of traveling to different states?” Ms. Collins asked. Students offered several suggestions: by car, by bus, by train, or by airplane.
- 3 “I have a fun and interesting way for all of us to see other parts of the country without packing a bag or buying a ticket,” said Ms. Collins. Students sat up a little straighter, eager to hear their teacher’s plan.
- 4 “Our class is going to **participate** in a picture-postcard exchange,” Ms. Collins explained. “We will send postcards with pictures of places in Nebraska to schools in other states. Each of you will send a postcard to a class in two different states. We have twenty-five students in our class. So we will send a postcard to each of the fifty states.”
- 5 The students were becoming enthusiastic about the project. They had lots of questions: where to send the postcards, how a postcard exchange works, and what to write about.
- 6 Ms. Collins waited until everyone was paying attention, and then she continued. “I will provide you with the addresses. Classes that receive a postcard will be asked to mail our class a postcard from their state. So we will exchange postcards with students in other states. When our class receives a postcard, we will place a pin on the class map to mark the state from which the postcard was mailed. I am hoping that we will have a pin in each of the 50 states by the end of the project.
- 7 “Let’s brainstorm some possible ideas about what to write on our postcards. Who can think of a topic that might interest other students? The ideas must be able to fit on a postcard,” stated Ms. Collins.
- 8 “We could write about our school,” said Lisa.
- 9 “We could write about our hobbies,” suggested Wilson.
- 10 “I think we should write about our state,” said Jordan. “Nebraska is a really interesting place.”
- 11 Ms. Collins nodded and encouraged Jordan to keep talking. “What kind of facts would you include?” she asked.

- 12 “I would send a postcard with a picture of the giant porch swing in Hebron, Nebraska,” said Jordan. “I could explain that the swing can hold 25 people at one time.”
- 13 “I would send a postcard with a picture of Boys Town in Omaha since it is a historical place,” said Marcus. “I could write about the statue of a boy carrying his brother.”
- 14 “Those are all good ideas,” said Ms. Collins. “Let’s have the class vote to decide what the postcards will be about.”
- 15 The class talked about the new project and voted that the postcards should tell something about their state. The students would ask the classes who received a postcard to tell something about their state as well. Then the postcard exchange would be like traveling to other states. Ms. Collins could tell that everyone was excited and eager to start.
- 16 The class used postcards that displayed a place of interest in Nebraska on the front. Students wrote some simple facts about the place of interest on the back of the postcard. They mailed the postcards and waited.
- 17 Excitement grew as the mail began to arrive with picture postcards for Ms. Collins’ class. Within two weeks, the classroom map was dotted with pins indicating the different states from which replies had been sent. Each postcard was read aloud when it arrived. Then it was placed in a special album kept at Ms. Collins’ desk. By the end of the month, 50 pins had been placed on the map. All the students were delighted to see a postcard from every state in the nation.
- 18 Students learned more about the states than they had ever known before. They had also gained a better understanding of their state by looking at the picture postcards of popular places in Nebraska. Students began to look up additional facts about the states to share with their classmates. Everyone agreed that the postcard-traveling experience had been a great success.

1. Which sentence BEST describes Ms. Collins?
 - A. She shares her hobbies with students.
 - B. She enjoys traveling to different places.
 - C. She visits relatives who live in other states.
 - D. She provides interesting learning experiences.

2. What does **participate** mean as used in paragraph 4?
 - A. to join
 - B. to watch
 - C. to talk about
 - D. to learn about

3. In paragraph 15, why does the story say that “the postcard exchange would be like traveling to other states”?
 - A. Exchanging postcards will be fun and exciting for the students.
 - B. Visiting new places will provide opportunities to get postcards.
 - C. Getting postcards will be a way of learning about different places.
 - D. Making Nebraska postcards will be an important learning experience.

4. Which sentence BEST states the theme of the story?

- A. Learning can be fun.
- B. Traveling is rewarding.
- C. Students must be prepared.
- D. Teachers have important jobs.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 5. Read the draft paragraph from Nathan’s essay.

If you travel along the rural Highway 75 in Thurston County, Nebraska, you might notice a sign called a historical marker. Historical markers are put up by the state government. The sign tells about 75 Winnebago tribe members who joined with the Nebraska Volunteers in 1865. Nebraska became the 37th state in 1867, two years after the Civil War. These tribe members helped keep peace between the settlers and other native tribes.

Which **two** sentences should Nathan remove to BEST stay on topic?

- A. If you travel along the rural Highway 75 in Thurston County, Nebraska, you might notice a sign called a historical marker.
- B. Historical markers are put up by the state government.
- C. The sign tells about 75 Winnebago tribe members who joined with the Nebraska Volunteers in 1865.
- D. Nebraska became the 37th state in 1867, two years after the Civil War.
- E. These tribe members helped keep peace between the settlers and other native tribes.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 6. Read Brianna's paragraph.

In the summer's morning sunlight, the water was gleaming and the surf felt refreshing on Jacob's feet. He had nothing to do that day, and was enjoying the fresh air. Gathering seashells and skipping stones as he went, Jacob was having a ball exploring the seemingly never-ending beach.

Brianna wants to make more precise word choices. Which word BEST replaces the word went in the paragraph?

- A. jogged
- B. moved
- C. passed
- D. wandered

Read the passage.

Birds of Nebraska

- 1 The state of Nebraska is a bird lover’s paradise. All year long, birds of all colors and sizes fly to and from the state. Around 460 species of birds can be spotted in Nebraska. In fact, birds are so beloved that festivals have even sprung up around some of these feathered celebrities.

The Sandhill Crane

- 2 Springtime in Nebraska brings with it a beautiful sight. Over a quarter of a million sandhill cranes begin to gather. They are getting ready for their migration north for the summer. These tall birds are known for their long legs. They stroll through water and over land in search of plants, rodents, bugs, and even snakes for food. Their loud trumpeting calls echo across the Platte River. The sky and ground are filled with their cream-colored feathers. These beautiful creatures help attract thousands of visitors to Nebraska year after year.

The White Pelican

- 3 Another **remarkable** gathering of birds occurs at the Harlan County Reservoir, where thousands of white pelicans soar majestically across the water and through the sky. Groups of up to 100 of these huge birds travel together. They steadily spiral upward using air currents to help them rise. With a wingspan of up to 9.5 feet, they can circle for long periods of time with little effort. The only North American bird with a greater wingspan than the pelican is the California condor. When it is time for a snack, the pelican floats on the water, scooping fish in its long beak. Pelicans often hunt together in shallow water, cooperating to direct fish toward one another. They eat around four pounds of fish a day, so this kind of cooperation is beneficial for them.

The Burrowing Owl

- 4 Long ago, cowboys riding across the plains began calling burrowing owls “howdy birds.” The small birds would pop their heads out of burrows in the ground and appear to give passersby a friendly nod as if wishing them well. Burrowing owls are still nodding in Nebraska today, though their numbers have declined. Efforts to reduce prairie dog populations have affected the owls as well. These speckled brown birds grow to a little less than one foot tall. They are also known for their strikingly bright yellow eyes, which help them to hunt at night. They mostly eat insects and small mammals. When danger is near, they will call out an alarm to warn other burrowing birds to seek the safety of their homes.
- 5 The sandhill crane, the white pelican, and the burrowing owl are only three of the fascinating birds that make their homes in Nebraska for at least part of the year. It is easy to see why birdwatchers flock to the state to watch and study these birds.

7. What is the MAIN reason why the author believes that Nebraska is a “bird lover’s paradise”?
- A. because Nebraska has birdwatchers visit the state
 - B. because Nebraska has three types of interesting birds
 - C. because Nebraska contains a small population of rare birds
 - D. because Nebraska is home to a large number and variety of birds
8. What can the reader infer about sandhill cranes?
- A. Sandhill cranes do not live in Nebraska all year.
 - B. Sandhill cranes lose their feathers when they hunt.
 - C. Sandhill cranes are more beautiful than white pelicans.
 - D. Sandhill cranes make sounds that are unusual for birds.
9. What does **remarkable** mean as used in paragraph 3?
- A. crowded
 - B. detailed
 - C. interesting
 - D. talkative

10. Which fact BEST supports the idea that Nebraska cowboys liked burrowing owls?
- A. The owls appeared to nod at the cowboys.
 - B. The cowboys gave the owls a cute nickname.
 - C. The cowboys rode across the plains where the owls lived.
 - D. The owl population was greater in the time of the cowboys.
11. Select **two** sentences from the passage that support the idea that some birds help each other.
- A. All year long, birds of all colors and sizes fly to and from the state.
 - B. These beautiful creatures help attract thousands of visitors to Nebraska year after year.
 - C. Pelicans often hunt together in shallow water, cooperating to direct fish toward one another.
 - D. The small birds would pop their heads out of burrows in the ground and appear to give passersby a friendly nod as if wishing them well.
 - E. When danger is near, they will call out an alarm to warn other burrowing birds to seek the safety of their homes.

12. How do the subheadings contribute to the reader's understanding of the passage?
- A. They organize the birds in chronological order.
 - B. They indicate which bird the author will describe.
 - C. They show how each bird is similar to the others.
 - D. They include additional information about each bird.
13. What is the author's purpose for writing the passage?
- A. to inform the reader about how birdwatchers gather during different seasons in Nebraska
 - B. to inform the reader about three interesting types of birds among many found in Nebraska
 - C. to inform the reader about the many places in Nebraska that are popular for birdwatching
 - D. to inform the reader about how some bird populations in Nebraska are thriving while others are declining

The item on this page is not passage-based.

★ 14. Read the student's persuasive essay.

Adopting a pet from a shelter can be a very rewarding experience. It can make people feel helpful to their furry friends because about 30,000 animals end up in Nebraska shelters every year. Another advantage of adopting a pet is that adopting costs less money than buying from a pet store or breeder. Lastly, having a pet is a great way to teach responsibility to children. There are many advantages to adopting a pet, and I hope you think about this the next time you are thinking about getting one.

Which **two** statements could the student add to the paragraph to support the opinion that having a pet teaches responsibility?

- A. Your friends will like to play with your pet.
- B. Pets can keep a person from being lonely.
- C. Most pets have to be fed and watered two times a day.
- D. Pets will make noise when a stranger comes to the door.
- E. Pets who stay mostly indoors need to be exercised every day.

The items on this page are not passage-based.

- ★ 15. Read the paragraph a student wrote about the butterfly life cycle.

Butterflies go through metamorphosis, or change, during their lives. The butterfly goes through a life cycle and the life cycle has four stages and the four stages are part of metamorphosis. The four stages of metamorphosis are egg, larva, pupa, and adult. Some butterflies go through the entire process in only four months, and other butterflies take up to a year.

Which sentence is the BEST revision of the underlined sentence?

- A. The butterfly's life cycle has four stages, which are part of metamorphosis.
- B. The butterfly goes through a life cycle that has four stages and are part of metamorphosis.
- C. The butterfly's life cycle has four stages, and each stage of the butterfly's life cycle is part of metamorphosis.
- D. The butterfly goes through a life cycle, the life cycle has four stages, and each stage is part of metamorphosis.

- ★ 16. Read the sentence.

Having finished our lunch we prepared for an early afternoon swim.

Which word in the sentence should be followed by a comma?

- A. lunch
- B. early
- C. finished
- D. prepared

Read the passage.

Pasta Pals

- 1** Ethan, Raj, and TJ jogged along the sidewalk, passing a soccer ball. While chatter of sports and school bounced between the three teammates, Luca trailed behind. He was so caught up in worrying about his plans that he could barely keep up with the others.
- 2** All four boys were on the soccer team; it was the first activity Luca had joined when he started at his new school. Now they were on their way to Luca's grandmother's house because Luca had promised his new teammates a delicious feast and a game of soccer later.
- 3** Earlier that week, Luca had mentioned to his grandmother that he would like to make friends at his new school, but he wasn't sure how. "Food is the glue that brings people together," Nonna had said. "Bring some of the boys from your soccer team here. We will make Italian pasta, and you will all become fast friends."
- 4** They arrived at Luca's house and there stood Nonna, smiling and beckoning them into her large, sunny kitchen.
- 5** "Guys, meet Giovanna Rossi—my nonna," Luca said.
- 6** He introduced each of his friends to Nonna and was surprised when TJ said, "TJ's short for Timothy James, ma'am. I'm named after my granddad. Can you tell me what smells so good?"
- 7** Nonna laughed, pointing to a large covered pot simmering on the stove. "It is our family recipe for red sauce. My nonna taught it to me when I was just a girl, and she learned it from her nonna back in Calabria, Italy. It cooks all day to bring out the best flavors."
- 8** "I've made spaghetti before," Ethan volunteered, "and macaroni and cheese plenty of times for my little sisters. It's easy."
- 9** "Noodles from a box are a time saver for busy families," Nonna agreed, "but there is great satisfaction in working with fresh ingredients and treasured recipes to create something special for your family and friends. How would you like to make your own pasta to use in ravioli?"
- 10** The boys hesitated for a moment, and Luca felt his palms grow sweaty.
- 11** "Do we get to eat what we make?" TJ asked.
- 12** "May I take some home to show my papa?" Raj added.
- 13** "Absolutely to both questions!" Nonna laughed.

- 14 Luca smiled in relief at his grandmother and she winked back. So far, so good.
- 15 In no time, the four boys were mixing small mountains of flour with eggs, water, and salt and laughing at the sticky mess squishing between their fingers. The laughter turned to groans when Nonna taught them to knead. Folding and flattening, turning and pounding the dough was entertaining at first, but after the necessary ten minutes, their arms felt as wobbly as wet noodles. They deposited their smooth, rounded pasta lumps beneath some plastic wrap to rest and then cheerfully accepted a treat of milk and crescent-shaped almond cookies.
- 16 With a large flour-coated rolling pin, Nonna demonstrated the next step. "Make your pasta as thin as possible," she said, lifting her flattened dough over her hand with her fingers spread wide. "If you can see your hand through the pasta, it's thin enough."
- 17 To cut the sheets of pasta into the appropriate shapes, Nonna brought out her bag of pasta tools. She showed the boys how to use a round cutter with scalloped edges to create perfect wavy-edged dough circles. Raj and Luca brushed half of the dough circles with an egg wash. Then TJ and Ethan dropped a meatball-sized scoop of the parmesan and ricotta cheese filling in the center.
- 18 Using Nonna's pasta tools, the boys cut the leftover dough into soccer balls, wiggly worms, and pasta-people. TJ stacked some of the soccer-ball shapes, saying, "Looks like a stack of pancakes, doesn't it?"
- 19 Everyone laughed.
- 20 By this time, the boys and even Nonna were hungry. A harmony of growling stomachs, bubbling pasta, and simmering seasoned sauce filled the kitchen. Nonna asked the boys to set the table with plates, glasses, and silverware. "This ravioli and sauce is the best I've ever eaten!" TJ proclaimed. "Would it be all right if we made pasta together again sometime? I had a lot of fun."
- 21 As Ethan and Raj enthusiastically agreed, Luca shared a **confidential** smile with Nonna. He was grateful Nonna had cooked up a plan to help him make new friends.

17. What does Nonna mean when she says that “Food is the glue that brings people together”?

- A. Creating new friendships is built on shared experiences.
- B. Finding new friends means connecting with many people.
- C. Joining together for a meal helps repair broken friendships.
- D. Building new friendships takes effort combined with patience.

18. **Read this sentence from the story.**

“The boys hesitated for a moment, and Luca felt his palms grow sweaty.”

What does the sentence reveal about Luca?

- A. He is nervous about his cooking skills.
- B. He thinks it is exciting to make ravioli.
- C. He is worried about the success of his grandmother’s plan.
- D. He thinks his grandmother should have used store-bought ravioli.

19. Select **two** examples from the story that show the closeness between Luca and Nonna.
- A. “Bring some of the boys from your soccer team here.”
 - B. “My nonna taught it to me when I was just a girl, and she learned it from her nonna back in Calabria, Italy.”
 - C. Luca smiled in relief at his grandmother and she winked back.
 - D. She showed the boys how to use a round cutter with scalloped edges to create perfect wavy-edged dough circles.
 - E. As Ethan and Raj enthusiastically agreed, Luca shared a confidential smile with Nonna.
20. Which sentence BEST describes a theme of the story?
- A. Everyone can learn how to make new friends.
 - B. Trying new foods together can build friendships.
 - C. Family members can be helpful in surprising ways.
 - D. Taking a chance on something new can lead to good results.

**NSCAS General Grade 5
Practice Test Answer Key
ELA**



Sequence	Key	Points
1	D	1
2	A	1
3	C	1
4	A	1
5	B, D	2
6	D	1
7	D	1
8	A	1
9	C	1
10	B	1
11	C, E	2
12	B	1
13	B	1
14	C, E	2
15	A	1
16	A	1
17	A	1
18	C	1
19	C, E	2
20	D	1